Zulafqar Ali

Principal Software Engineer | PHP · Laravel · Symfony · Microservices · AWS · SuiteCRM

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Professional Summary

Principal Software Engineer with 10+ years of experience building and scaling backend systems in PHP (Laravel, Symfony, Yii2). Delivered microservices platforms on AWS serving millions of users, and SuiteCRM solutions for healthcare recruitment (AI-assisted screening and job matching) and tax/accounting workflows with real-time QuickBooks synchronization. Strong in requirements analysis, solution design, REST API development, CI/CD, production debugging, code review and mentoring. Has led teams of 4 to 6 engineers and collaborated in cross-functional teams of up to 40.

Technical Skills

- **Backend:** PHP, Laravel, Symfony, Yii2, CodeIgniter, Zend, REST APIs, JSON, microservices, OOP, MVC, design patterns, Python (working knowledge)
- **Databases and Caching:** MySQL, AWS Aurora, Redis, MS SQL, SQLite
- **Cloud and DevOps:** AWS (Aurora, CI/CD pipelines), Docker, GitLab CI/CD, Git, GitHub, Bitbucket
- **CRM and Integrations:** SuiteCRM, SugarCRM, QuickBooks Online API and PHP SDK, third-party and payment gateway integrations
- **Frontend:** JavaScript, jQuery, AJAX, HTML5, CSS3, Vue.js, AngularJS
- **Practices and Tools:** Agile/Scrum, sprint planning, code review, requirements analysis, solution design, technical mentoring, Jira, Teamwork, Trello, Redmine, PHPStorm

Professional Experience

Principal Software Engineer, Tkxel, Lahore, Pakistan

Dec 2022 to Present

Tech: PHP, Laravel, microservices, MySQL, AWS Aurora, Redis, Docker, AWS CI/CD, GitLab, REST APIs, SuiteCRM, Jira

Cafe Zupas: online ordering platform (80+ restaurant branches, millions of users, 40-engineer team)

- Built backend services on a Laravel microservices architecture on AWS, supporting online ordering across 80+ branches and millions of users.
- Implemented custom item preparation, loyalty programs, automatic kitchen-to-customer order status updates, payment gateway integrations and delivery workflows.
- Set up AWS CI/CD deployment pipelines for automated releases.
- Debugged and resolved production issues on the live system.
- Analyzed client requirements and translated them into technical solutions within a 40-engineer cross-functional team.

eDocs: document digitization and e-signature application (team of 12)

- Analyzed client requirements, defined the solution and implemented core application functionality for digitizing and signing documents.

Healthcare recruitment platform on SuiteCRM (AI-enabled, team of 10, ongoing)

- Building a SuiteCRM-based recruitment solution for the healthcare sector, used by 7,000+ CRM users and handling thousands of resumes and applications.
- Delivered AI-assisted features including candidate assessments, resume screening and building, survey generation and profile-to-job matching.
- Defined solution architecture from client requirements and set up deployment pipelines.

Across projects

- Mentor junior developers, conduct code reviews and enforce coding standards.

Senior Software Engineer, CarSwitch, Lahore, Pakistan

Jan 2022 to Dec 2022

Tech: PHP, Yii2, MySQL, JavaScript, jQuery, AJAX, HTML5, CSS3, Git, GitLab, Jira

- Translated product-team requirements into technical solutions, breaking down tasks and estimating effort.
- Delivered application features on time using sound engineering practices.
- Diagnosed and resolved complex design and technical issues.
- Provided technical support for clients across local and global sites.
- Delivered internal tech sessions to the engineering team.

Senior Software Engineer, Rolustech, Lahore, Pakistan

Jan 2020 to Jan 2022

Tech: PHP, SuiteCRM, SugarCRM, MySQL, QuickBooks Online API, JavaScript, jQuery, AJAX, Git, Crystal Reports

ttgat.us: tax audit and accounting CRM (SuiteCRM)

- Customized SuiteCRM into a tax audit platform covering business audits, invoicing, payments and work-progress tracking for 200+ CRM users.
- Re-engineered data-processing and accounting-book workflows, handling roughly 50 GB of financial data.
- Built real-time, two-way synchronization of financial data between the CRM and QuickBooks Online.

Xension: device insurance and repair CRM

- Automated manual insurance and mobile-device repair processes in a custom CRM to speed up case handling.
- Implemented role-based access and task assignment and tracking for hundreds of users, supporting millions of requests.

Team and delivery

- Led teams of 4 to 6 engineers and QAs across multiple projects, running daily scrums and bi-weekly sprints and shipping on schedule.
- Provided client support for local and global sites and delivered internal tech sessions.

Software Engineer, Rolustech, Lahore, Pakistan

Mar 2017 to Dec 2019

Tech: PHP, MySQL, SugarCRM, SuiteCRM, JavaScript, jQuery, AJAX, HTML5, CSS3, Git

- Worked with development and QA teams to design and build solutions meeting client requirements for functionality, scalability and performance.
- Identified and resolved complex design and technical issues across projects.
- Provided end-user support to clients on local and global sites.

Web Developer, EGlobal Solution, Lahore, Pakistan

Jul 2014 to Jan 2017

- Converted design mockups into working websites using HTML, JavaScript, AJAX and JSON.
- Planned and implemented website changes and integrations to streamline client business operations.

Education

Bachelor of Science in Computer Science, The University of Lahore, 2012 to 2016

Certifications

SugarCRM Developer Certification